
Paper 1, Option 1D:

Britain, c1785–c1870: democracy, protest and reform

Overview

This option comprises a study in breadth, in which students will learn about the process of change in Britain in the given period, and the extent to which popular pressure, protest and cooperation were responsible for political, economic and social change.

The focus of study is on developments and changes over a broad timescale and so the content is presented as themes spanning a significant duration: c1785–c1870. This option also contains a study in depth of historical interpretations on a broad question that is contextualised by, and runs parallel to, the themes: reasons for the abolition of the slave trade at the end of the period, c1785–1807.

Themes	Content
1 The growth of parliamentary democracy, c1785–c1870	• The unreformed parliament and its critics, c1785–1820: the pre-reform electorate, parliamentary seats and elections; demands for reform; the political demands of the manufacturing interest. • Pressure for change and reform, 1820–52: economic and social distress, and popular pressure, 1820–32; reasons for the passing of the Great Reform Act 1832 and its significance; Chartist demands and the failure of Chartism; change and continuity in the new electoral landscape. • Further parliamentary reform, 1852–70; the significance of the National Reform Union and the Reform League; changing political attitudes in the 1860s and the impact of the Reform Act 1867.
2 Industrialisation and protest, c1785–c1870	• The impact of industrialisation: the growth of banking, investment and a new industrial middle class; the diversity of economic regions; the growth of industrial towns and cities. Government attitudes towards industrial development. • Working conditions in factories, mines and foundries; female and child labour; living conditions in urban areas. • Industrialisation, protest and reform: the changing nature and effectiveness of industrial protest, 1785–1870; the significance of Luddism, and the Swing Riots; the Ten Hour Movement; support for, opposition to, and the impact of factory reform, 1833–70, including the importance of the Factory Act 1833 and factory reforms of 1844–64; reforms affecting living conditions, 1848–70.

Themes	Content
3 Unionism and cooperation, c1785–c1870	• Unions and their opponents, c1785–1834: trade societies and knobsticks; reasons for, and impact of, the growth of trade unions; government response to trade unions. • New model unionism 1835–70, including the significance of the Amalgamated Society of Engineers, the founding of the Trades Union Congress 1868, and the government response to new unionism. • The growth of cooperative activities: New Lanark and cooperative activities; the Rochdale Pioneers and cooperative economics; the growth of the friendly societies.
4 Poverty and pauperism, c1785–c1870	• The old Poor Law and pressure for change: the implementation and effectiveness of poor relief before 1834, attitudes towards the poor and the influence of utilitarianism; financial and ideological pressures for change. • The impact and effectiveness of the Poor Law Amendment Act 1834: the workhouse regime, less eligibility and the continuation of outdoor relief; nature and extent of opposition to the Poor Law. • Changing attitudes towards the poor and pauperism, 1834–70: the impact of the Andover workhouse scandal on national opinion; the growth of charity and self-help; the significance of key individuals, including Dickens and Smiles, in challenging attitudes.

Historical interpretations	Content
What explains the abolition of the slave trade at the end of the period, c1785–1807?	• The importance of humanitarian campaigns and the influence of religion. • The significance of economic and financial factors. • The significance of individuals, including Thomas Clarkson, William Wilberforce, Olaudah Equiano. • The changing political climate, including the fear of slave resistance.